THE REPUBLIC OF HAPPINESS

In a world riven by wars and calamities, a few **outstanding initiatives by individuals and institutions across India** have brought contentment to many

By **KAUSHIK DEKA** / *Illustration by* NILANJAN DAS

The pursuit of happiness has always been a collective aspiration. There may have been civilisational differences in how happiness is perceived, but the yearning for joy, contentment and a sense of well-being has been a universal phenomenon. And then, just as we were struggling to cope with the post-pandemic world order came two unwarranted wars—Russia and Ukraine in Eastern Europe and Israel and Palestine in West Asia. It seems there will be no end to the 'unhappiness'.

However, the unprecedented deaths and destruction once again remind us of what is wrong and what is the cure. And it all starts with the ancient Indian wisdom—'*Sarve bhavantu sukhinah* (Let everybody be happy)'. In 2011, a United Nations General Assembly resolution declared happiness as a 'fundamental human goal' recognising this vision. In 2015, the UN launched 17 Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs), which seek to end poverty, reduce inequality and protect our planet—the three key pillars essential for our well-being and happiness.

Our search for collective happiness, though, often begins with small endeavours, which eventually build up to the well-being of many. Since 2016, INDIA TODAY has been celebrating such efforts by bringing out an edition that chronicles stories of hope and happiness. In the following pages, you will read about individuals, initiatives and groups that have trudged the untrodden path to make a positive difference to society. They are not the usual charitable do-gooders but people and institutions who have developed sustainable, inclusive and actionable plans with economic value. Take the civil servant in West Bengal who tweaked a government scheme to help farmers diversify and enhance their income. Or a women's self-help group in Odisha finding financial self-sufficiency by joining the state's Millet Mission. Then there is the story of the skilled migrant labourers who lost their jobs and returned home to Bihar during the pandemic. Today, they are textile entrepreneurs making good profits and giving employment to many.

In all these stories, there is a common link—the pursuit of happiness has not been just about their own progress. All of them embarked on a collective journey. These are the actions that make our world a better place. ■